

"I don't feel lonely because I don't work alone most of the time": Exploring Gig Work as an Opportunity for Social Participation Among Older Adults

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Abstract

There has been increasing interest in why people participate in the gig economy, especially older adults. However, fewer studies have focused on the potential social benefits of older adults participating in gig work. We conducted semi-structured interviews with 14 older adults in the U.S. about their perceived social benefits of working as online personal shoppers. We found that gig work allowed for different levels of social activities for older adults, including (a) being with others, (b) interacting with others, (c) doing an activity with others, and (d) helping others. Our findings contribute insights into how hybrid gig work could benefit older adults' social participation post-retirement.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI; • Social and professional topics → Seniors.

Keywords

Older adults, gig work, gig economy, hybrid gig work, social participation

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1 Introduction

Electronically mediated workers, including crowd and gig workers, are a general class of workers who obtain short jobs or tasks online, through an app or a website [9]. These workers account for 1% of total employment in the United States, with those 55 and over accounting for 0.8% of all workers in that age group [1]. Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) researchers have explored the benefits and tradeoffs of gig work and the reasons for participation [4, 6, 7, 15, 23, 27–30]. While studies suggest that education level

can make it more difficult for older adults to find jobs in the gig economy [2], research suggests gig work could be a valuable income source for older adults in semi-retirement [8]. Fewer studies overall have focused on older adults' participation in gig work. Yet, some researchers have explored why older adults participate in gig work [6, 21, 28] to understand the financial and cognitive benefits. Studies among younger adults have also found that gig work can have social benefits [25]. However, there is still limited knowledge about the social benefits of older adults participating in gig work, particularly those who choose to do so after retirement.

We explore the potential perceived social benefits of older adults engaging in hybrid gig work post-retirement. Using online personal shopping (e.g., Instacart, Shipt) as an example, we explore the distinct social benefits of hybrid gig work that includes offline tasks compared to crowd work. We interviewed 14 retired older adults (60+ years old) who were self-employed or platform-based gig workers conducting online personal shopping. Participants found this type of gig work to be a flexible option for meeting their financial needs while also a valuable means of meeting social needs through connecting with others, building community, and helping others. We discuss opportunities for gig work to support older adults' social needs, aligning perceived social opportunities of hybrid gig work with the different levels of social participation needs of older adults [20]. Our study contributes to the fields of HCI by highlighting older adults' experiences in the gig economy and exploring the social benefits of gig work among older adults.

2 RELATED WORK

Since the publication of *The Gig Economy* by Mulcahy [24], there has been growing emphasis in the field of Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) to study gig work and gig workers [31]. The term "gig" originally comes from the music industry [11]. However, within the gig economy, "gig work" often refers to an electronically mediated form of work where workers obtain short jobs or tasks online, through an app or a website [33]. Gig work can be categorized into two main types: online and hybrid (offline). This can include crowd work performed entirely online that is not geographically bound, or hybrid work, such as personal shopping and deliveries, where individuals take orders online but complete the work offline, making it geographically constrained [33]. Examples include English teachers in the Philippines [26] and legal consultants in China [35] as well as hybrid positions such as food delivery workers [13], Uber and Lyft drivers [12], and beauty professionals in India [4]. Researchers have explored why different groups participate



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in gig work to understand their diverse experiences and the potential trade-offs associated with this type of work [22, 23, 28, 30]. However, interest in specifically exploring the experiences of older adults as gig workers has also grown [8, 10, 21].

Older adult workers, typically grouped as those 55 years of age or older, account for 0.8% of all electronically mediated workers [1]. In the HCI field, researchers have aimed to understand the older adults' experiences in the gig economy. For example, Tang and colleagues studied older adult content producers and influencers' experiences to explore their work as content creators on short video platforms [32]. Lin and colleagues explored the practices of older adult gig workers as care workers, finding that they provide both paid and unpaid care via caregiving platforms [21]. Studies have also explored older adults' motivation for doing crowd work. For example, Kobayashi and colleagues have studied designing crowd work tasks that are specific to older adults' needs [17]. Brewer and colleagues found that older adults see cognitive benefits to engaging in crowd work, but rank social benefits as limited [6]. Therefore, although fewer in number, these studies have highlighted some of the benefits and trade-offs of different types of gig work for older adults. We build on this work to explore the social reasons older adults have for engaging in gig work, advancing our understanding of how hybrid gig work tasks present social opportunities.

3 METHODS

We conducted qualitative interviews with 14 older adults (age 60+). After receiving IRB protocol approval, the first author recruited participants through Reddit post on /instacart subchannels and through referral from other participants. In the post, we briefly introduced our study and included a link to a screening survey that was used to identify eligible participants. Participants were required to: (1) Live in the United States, (2) Speak English, (3) Be 60 years of age or older, (4) Be retired from full employment or receive retirement benefits and (5) Perform personal shopping through an app receiving customer orders and physically going to stores to buy goods and deliver them to their homes.

After eligible participants were identified, we sent emails to inform them of the study details, scheduled a 1-hour remote interview with them using Zoom, a video conference software, and asked them to complete a background survey prior to the interview. Participants worked as online personal shoppers from different cities in the United States, and all were retired from previous jobs (See Appendix). Ten participants were aged 60–64, and four were aged 65–69. Five participants had been retired for 4–6 years, eight for 1–3 years, and one for 7–10 years. Nine participants had a bachelor's degree, and five had a master's degree. Among those participants, one was identified as self-employed. Nine participants worked for Instacart, one for TaskRabbit, one for Amazon Prime Now, and two for Shipt. We addressed two research questions: **(1) What motivates and influences older adults' decisions to work as online personal shoppers in grocery delivery after retirement?** **(2) To what extent does gig work fulfill the social expectations of older adults, and what are its implications for their post-retirement well-being?**

During interviews, we asked participants about their motivations and experiences working as an online personal shopper after

retirement, the challenges they faced while working, their social expectations for the work, and how the work fulfilled those expectations. We audio-recorded all interviews with participants' consent. All sessions were transcribed, and manually cleaned and corrected. Interview sessions lasted approximately 30–60 minutes. Each participant received a \$20 Walmart Gift Card for completing the study. To analyze the qualitative data, we employed thematic analysis [5] to identify common patterns related to the perceived social benefits of engaging in gig work. We first selected a subset of transcripts from the dataset's corpus to review and take notes. Following, we created a codebook that included codes and themes that we applied to the remaining dataset.

4 FINDINGS

Our findings suggest that older adults chose gig work as a transition phase from working full-time to retirement. They chose online personal shopping primarily to earn additional income but also valued the flexibility of the work. We also learned that participants appreciated the different kinds of social participation brought by the work and how the social benefits positively impacted their well-being, including reducing their loneliness.

4.1 Life After Retirement and Choosing Gig Work

Participants chose to retire for various reasons; some wanted to retire early, while others chose to retire due to aging factors. As P2 mentioned, *"So I had to retire because my age factor is coming in, and I can't step up with lots of work at the construction company."* Participants shared different experiences adjusting after retirement. Some participants mentioned spending more time resting, being with their family, and taking care of their health (P2, P7, P11). Participants also viewed retirement as an opportunity to reflect on their future directions and consider what they want to do next (P5, P6). However, other participants reported feeling a loss of structure in their day and managing idle time and loneliness. P4 mentioned, *"So let me go back to when I was working every day I woke up, I woke up with a motive. I woke up knowing I'm going to school [as a teacher]. I have certain projects. I have certain lessons that I'm going to teach and et cetera. But once I retired, I woke up, and I realized I had nothing to do with my day... My wife was still working, and is still working. Our children are all grown up, so I'm most of the part of the day. I'm left alone at the house. ... I think it gets inside you and you might start having a lot of thoughts, a lot of even my little depression, because you are thinking a lot and you are not doing anything productive."* Several other participants noted cases where they felt idle, bored, or lonely at home, leading them to search for new job opportunities and eventually online personal shopping.

Some participants noted they initially tried more traditional 9-to-5 jobs, but found them less flexible compared to online personal shopping. Others tried other forms of gig work, but settled on online personal shopping due to its flexibility and the potential for social interaction. P1 mentioned, *"Yeah, you know, in the Uber Eats, I was just spending my time... and like it didn't involve a lot of interactions. Yeah, but this one [online personal shopping], I can interact with people. Both online. Yeah, through the phone. And also physically"*. Participants believe that personal shopping could be a

way to address their needs and changing values regarding work, including opportunities for social participation.

4.2 Gig Work as an Opportunity for Social Participation for Retired Older Adults

While most of our participants acknowledged earning an income as their primary or partial reason for considering online personal shopping as their chosen type of gig work, we found that our participants viewed working as online personal shoppers as a way to socially participate in society.

4.2.1 Gig Work as a way to stay active. Some participants reported feeling bored and idle. They found online personal shopping as a "thing to do", not necessarily for the benefit of interacting with people, but as a way to be outside of their home and to keep them busy. Several participants mentioned staying active as their initial reason to consider this job. As P11 mentioned, *"Even at a younger age I've always been a determined person who doesn't like things being the same for a long time. So after retirement. I had to get myself busy sometimes, not because the pay is big, or because it pays more, but just to get out of the house once in a while, just to get myself busy, not to feel idle."* Other participants reported that in retirement, they should stay active for their health, as suggested by their health providers. As P7 mentioned, *"Well, I've always been someone that I don't know how to be idle. I love having something to do. So when I discussed with my healthcare provider. We decided that. Okay. Even though I am not so well, I can still be doing something that, you know, isn't too stressful, something that is pleasurable, that I can always rest whenever I feel like resting, unlike when I was teaching"*. From the participant's perspective, being an online personal shopper was not just a job; it also provided opportunities to move around, which was good for their health.

4.2.2 Gig Work as a way to interact with people. Participants also mentioned that they saw online personal shopping as a way to interact with and communicate with people, both online and offline, including customers and other online personal shoppers. P12 mentioned, *"It has helped me socially to interact with customers through messaging and delivering to friendly customers. It gives me a personal social experience and also meeting store employees it has helped me to build relationship with them. And also it has helped me to have a flexible schedule for my social life, like I can choose hours to stay with my family friends, or even do my hobbies ..."* Not only does this work help participants maintain social life out of work, but participants also reported that they made friendships with their customers through their job. These friendships were formed naturally and as a byproduct of the work. One participant shared that forming friendships is a natural process that can occur through interaction with customers. P3 mentioned, *"I have, I actually have a group of ladies who like to do art. So I met them through the job. Also. I've met a girl who I'm mentoring now through the job. So yeah. ... It's a mix, there's a friend I've met recently that has introduced me to our community of people who go on walks every week. So yeah, it has helped. If it wasn't for this job I wouldn't have been able to make that friend because I wasn't an outgoing person from before ... Some people that I do orders for end up being close friends. So yeah."*

Some participants also mentioned collaborating with other online personal shoppers as colleagues, where they would form a team to share knowledge and notify each other when there is an order they might be interested in. P12 mentioned *"I don't feel lonely because I don't work alone most of the time, because I get to talk to my coworkers, and also the customer interactions are not short... the job that I have that I work in does not lack a social environment."*

4.2.3 Gig Work as a way to help people. Participants reported that they also saw their job as a way to help people. Participants saw shopping and delivering goods to their customers as a way to contribute to their community. They mentioned that some of their customers are people with disabilities, older adults, or busy parents, and they felt they were being helpful. P6 mentioned, *"I also enjoy helping people, I've always enjoyed. And this [job] actually provides me the platform to do so, and many of my customers are elderly, busy parents, or people with disabilities who can't always make it to the store, knowing I'm making their day easier, gives me a sense of purpose again."* Participants acknowledged that one of the enjoyable aspects of the job was helping people, even though they did not expect this when they initially began work. P3 mentioned, *"At first it [the job] started as a part-time thing, and then I ended up enjoying it really. Doing delivery of what I've seen is that I get to help people, especially the people living with disabilities. They don't have to struggle to go get items. I can do that. So I'm impacting the community."* Through this job, participants also encountered acquaintances as their customers who may need emotional support through conversation. P8 shared how they ended up reconnecting with a high-school friend through their job, *"I just think my happiest moment would be the moment where I got an old high-school friend [as a customer]. ... I got to know she's suffering. Obviously, she is suffering from cancer, but the memories were wonderful. We got to spend a lot of time, you know. We exchanged contact, and we had to sit out with our family and eat dinner, and that was a very good, memorable one."*

5 Discussion and Conclusions

Prior work suggests people have different motivations for participating in gig work, including monetary [3] and non-monetary reasons such as flexibility [18, 19]. Prior work has also explored the different reasons older adults participate in various forms of gig work, including caregiving [21] and online crowd work [6]. Research has found that among multi-generational crowd workers, older adults may be promising candidates for crowd tasks that have social goals (i.e., social-purpose work) [16]. Gig work could also offer varying amounts of social interactions for older adults with disabilities living alone as a way to mitigate loneliness [28]. Other work notes the potential cognitive benefits of older adults participating in crowd work platforms, but notes that social factors were viewed as less important [6]. We found, in contrast, that the opportunities for on-the-job interaction offered older adult gig workers in our study an appealing combination of benefits that aligned with their need to meet financial goals, maintain flexibility, and address different levels of social needs through various types of social interaction. Participants saw social benefits beyond the delivery phase, where shoppers interact with a customer when dropping off an order, and felt their work provided moments of social interaction between customers and workers that they appreciated. We discuss

Table 1: Perceived social benefit of work tasks and alignment with social activity levels for older adults' well-being [20]. * Some levels of social activity were not directly observed during work tasks, but came as a byproduct.

Phenomenon	Levels of Social Activity [20]
Not being idle and getting outside of the house; Being in public places with others	Being with others (alone but with people around)
Messaging customers for item substitutions; Delivering goods; Talking with store employees and other shoppers about work tasks	Interacting with others (social contact) without doing a specific activity
Reconnecting with friends*; Making new friends*; Joining civic and recreational groups*; Working with other colleagues	Doing an activity with others (collaborating to reach the same goal)
Delivering goods to busy people, people with disabilities, and other older adults	Helping others

the different ways participants perceived their work as beneficial to meeting their social participation needs, aligning their experiences with a taxonomy of social activity from social science literature [20], which highlights the different levels of social participation that can benefit older adults.

5.1 The Role of Hybrid Gig Work For Meeting Older Adults' Social Participation Needs

We found that participants' social motivations for engaging in personal shopping gig work after retirement could be unpacked into three main social needs aligning with different social goals: (1) staying active and getting outside of the house (e.g., not being idle), (2) directly interact with others, online and offline, and (3) delivering goods to help others. Beyond just being social, the type of gig work they chose, which emphasized online and offline (hybrid) interactions with customers, colleagues, and store employees, aligns with other research noting the potential benefits of working in older age [34]. In the social sciences, the social participation needs of older adults are presented as a layered and complex set of activities that can be achieved in various ways beyond typical social-focused interactions (e.g., engaging in intentionally social activities or conversations) [14]. Levasseur and colleagues found that older adults often benefit from different levels of social activity, including short interactions like doing an activity in preparation for connecting with others or being with others alone but with people around [20]. Our work suggests that for certain job-related tasks required in hybrid gig work, these tasks also meet older adults' needs for social participation, aligning with Levasseur's taxonomy of social activities that benefit well-being (See Table 1).

We found that for some of our participants, being out of the house was socially beneficial, as they could work alone but also be around others when shopping for goods (See Table 1). These different tasks, which may not be readily perceived as social tasks, correspond to social activities such as checking out at the grocery store, where an individual is around others but not engaging them for "social" tasks [20]. Additionally, we found that participants described levels of social activities that involved direct interaction with others (for social contact) without doing a specific social activity together, such as interacting with people while shopping to find an item [20]. For example, communicating with customers or store employees to complete their shopping tasks. We also found that as participants saw opportunities to help others and contribute to society through

their work [20]. Participants described their work as helping those who may need assistance getting essential goods to their homes due to limited mobility or inflexible schedules viewing their work more broadly at times as opportunities to provide care, which gave them a sense of social purpose. However, we found that while participants did not engage in social activities that directly allowed them to do a "social" activity with others (collaborating to reach the same goal), they did find that these social opportunities sometimes came as a byproduct of the work instead of resulting from direct work tasks. Participants noted that, while initially they did not engage with the intention of forming friendships, some did discuss how interactions with customers led to social opportunities, such as getting together for recreation or civic activities. Participants noted that, first and foremost, the interaction was for their job tasks, but they also appreciated the opportunity to meet customers from different backgrounds, which they felt was beneficial for their social well-being. Further, while acknowledging the differences in our participants and study context, previous research suggested that gig workers involved in deliveries may experience social isolation [29, 30] yet our findings indicate that this type of work could meet different social needs of older adults.

5.2 Limitations and Conclusions

Although our study provides new insights into older adults' gig work experiences, it also has potential limitations. We recruited our participants from online communities, mainly Reddit; therefore, our study favors those who have technology skills and may not include those who are offline or have limited digital literacy. Our definition of retirement was based on age (>60) and current receipt of retirement benefits. These criteria are also based primarily on retirement practices in the United States, where most retirement accounts allow withdrawals beginning at 59 and 1/2, and Social Security benefits begin at 62. Our results may not transfer to other contexts where retirement policies and practices differ. Eligibility was based on participants' self-reported data and was not verified by the research team in any other way. Our findings may also not be applicable to older adults who rely on gig work as their primary source of income.

In conclusion, our study presents the experiences of older adults participating in Gig Work after retirement. We found that older adults in our study did not treat gig work as their main source of income, and their main goal was not to be idle at home. Therefore, our participants continued in this type of work for social benefits,

to connect with others, and to combat the loneliness they feel after retirement. Our findings extend work in HCI and the Future of Work, exploring the reasons people engage in the gig economy, particularly older adult retirees' motivations for hybrid gig work and the perceived benefits for their social participation.

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A Demographic Data

Here we present our participants' detailed demographic data table, which was mentioned in Section 3.

Table 2: Participant Demographics

P#	Location	Previous Jobs	Age	Platform	Working Hours	Highest Education	Living Arrangement	Retired Years
P1	Houston, Texas	Teacher	65-69	Self-employed	11-15 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	with a spouse or partner	4-6
P2	Florida	Structural Engineer	60-64	Instacart	26-30 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	alone	7-10
P3	Houston, Texas	Pre School Tutor	60-64	Instacart	5-10 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	with a spouse or partner	1-3
P4	New York	Teacher	60-64	Amazon Prime Now	16-20 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	alone	1-3
P5	St. Paul, Minnesota	Warehouse Manager	60-64	Instacart	16-20 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	alone	4-6
P6	Indianapolis, Indiana	Nurse	60-64	Instacart	16-20 h/week	Master degree (eg. MA, MS, MBA)	with a spouse or partner	1-3
P7	Indianapolis, Indiana	Teacher	60-64	Shipt	26-30 h/week	Master degree (eg. MA, MS, MBA)	with other family members (not spouse or partner)	1-3
P8	Indianapolis, Indiana	Construction worker	65-69	Instacart	26-30 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	with a spouse or partner	4-6
P9	Indianapolis, Indiana	Office Administrator	65-69	Instacart	31-35 h/week	Master degree (eg. MA, MS, MBA)	with a spouse or partner	1-3
P10	Chicago, Illinois	Teaching, Chef, Social Media Manager	60-64	Task Rabbit	5-10 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	with a spouse or partner	4-6
P11	Miami, Florida	Accountant	60-64	Instacart	11-15 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	with a spouse or partner	4-6
P12	Dallas, Texas	Software Engineer	60-64	Instacart	21-25 h/week	Bachelor degree (eg. BA, BS)	with a spouse or partner	1-3
P13	Indianapolis, Indiana	Retail Manager	65-69	Instacart	16-20 h/week	Master degree (eg. MA, MS, MBA)	with other family members (not spouse or partner)	1-3
P14	Indianapolis, Indiana	Teacher	60-64	Shipt	21-25 h/week	Master degree (eg. MA, MS, MBA)	with a spouse or partner	1-3